from the other, and most times so contradictory, that even by much seeking one could not find the clue to his thoughts.' The Jesuits would have reason to lament their failure to understand the Padshah's innermost thoughts, even unto his deathbed. But even at a much earlier stage, Akbar was an enigma, and those who grew complacent in their certainty, like Adham Khan, found themselves taken unawares by his unpredictable outrage. And while Akbar chose to ignore Asaf Khan's treachery, in due time, it was not only his foster family but even his own family members who would be called upon to explain their every dubious action.

Khwaja Muazzam, brother of Hamida Banu, had always been an unstable character, gloating in his infallible closeness to the imperial family and showing, in shocking acts of violence, a simmering insanity. He had murdered servants of the family and had been banished to Mecca. Now he had returned and lived outside Agra 'in utter immoderation', married to the daughter of Bibi Fatima, the superintendent of the royal harem. Bibi Fatima came to plead with Akbar one day, saying that Muazzam was threatening to go to his fief and drag his wife with him where, she was certain, he would harm her. 'He is so mean and suspicious,' wept Bibi Fatima, 'that he will kill the poor innocent.' Akbar consoled the woman and said he would forbid Muazzam from taking his wife away and sailed down the Yamuna with a group of courtiers to confront his uncle. Two men were sent ahead to warn Muazzam of Akbar's arrival but this infuriated Muazzam who screamed at them: 'I will not go before the Emperor!' He then strode into his wife's quarters and stabbed her to death. Throwing the dagger out of the window he shouted out to the men below saying 'I have shed her blood. Go tell him that.' When Akbar was shown the bloody dagger he was enraged and stormed into Muazzam's inner quarters. 'What manner is this?' shouted the Padshah. 'You have a hand on the hilt of your sword. If you move it, know that I will give you such a blow that your head will go flying,' threatened Akbar and, noticing that one of Muazzam's men looked menacing, shouted out an order to his courtier who swung his sword and cut off the man's head.

Muazzam was then bound and taken down to the river, screaming incoherently. The courtiers tried to drown Muazzam, 'with whom they had shared cups in drunkenness', but the man was resilient. Every time he came up for air, 'knowing that to curse the great men of religion shocks Akbar, he keeps up a stream of curses'. Here again, even if obliquely via Muazzam's